

Sintel is an independently produced short film, initiated by the Blender Foundation. In the tradition of code-naming each of its open movie projects after fruits, this fourth project from the Blender Institute is called Project Durian (a fruit native to Indonesia, Malaysia and other south east Asian countries). The main idea behind these projects has been to facilitate Blender development, and give an impetus to the open movie programme. The Blender Foundation started the open movie project back in 2005, with the release of the highly acclaimed 'Elephants Dream'. Ever since this first success, the Blender Foundation has continued releasing open projects under various categories, featuring and developing different aspects of the open 3D modelling software, Blender.

The Blender Foundation's varied open projects include three open movies, and an open game. Every project is unique, and focuses on certain features for Blender development. The third open movie project converged towards the development of the next stable release, 2.5/2.6. Likewise, the full Sintel movie was developed on the Blender development branch.

The beginning

The project was initiated on May 5, 2009, under the guidance of Colin Levy (director), David Revoy (art director) and Ton Roosendaal, steering the production of the movie. The project was inspired by the works of a famous Dutch comic writer, Martin Lodewijk. Like with other projects, artists were welcomed to showcase their talents by creating a spell-binding movie. Far exceeding the Blender Foundation's hopes, a whopping 150 artists showed interest in working on the next open movie, though the list was pared down to five to begin with, later being increased to a team of 18 whose work included the storyboard, production, consultancy and development. The initial five artists were Angela Guenette (for modelling, rigging, animation), Ben Dansie (a 3D generalist), Nathan Vegdahl (rigging, animation), Lee Salvemini (animation) and Soenke Maeter (shading, light, compositing).

The Blender Foundation was determined to avoid the shortcomings of its earlier open movie project, Peach, which had a weak story line. To present a dramatic short film, the Foundation approached Esther Wouda for the story line. With this aspect entirely under her command, she worked closely with the rest of the team. The film got financial support from the Netherlands Film Funds, leading to further enhancement and an expansion of the project. Several more sponsors coming on board led to the inclusion of high-end goals like a 4k render of the film; the duration of the movie was also increased considerably from ~8min to ~15mins. Subsequently, more artists were hired for the swift development of the project.

The movie

"Sintel is epic, dark and a complete make-over from the previous projects..." was part of the brief given to the team working on the movie. Sintel is, indeed, dark and gloomy

when compared to the earlier open movies from Blender. Remember the chivalrous bunny that made us laugh in Big Buck Bunny, and Proog, the tour-guide in Elephants Dream?

However, Sintel will enthrall you with its spectacular graphics and life-like animation. The movie begins with soothing sounds, depicting a wilderness of icy peaks where Sintel, the main character, seems to be wandering after she's been attacked by the 'gatekeeper of dragon land'.

In the first half of the movie, Sintel narrates the happenings in her life, and the latter half is when all the drama and action takes place. As the film proceeds, we notice the beautiful Sintel living in a pitiful condition in a remote part of the village. Strong and fearless, she carries a dagger; and her bravery, combined with her motherly instincts, leads her to treat an injured baby dragon.

Soon, both develop a great deal of affection for each other. But one sad day, the baby dragon is snatched away by an adult dragon, and that has a tyrannical effect on Sintel's mind. Outraged, she marches over tough terrains, brimming with anger at losing her beloved baby dragon, and risking her life to find it. Sintel tries to rescue the baby dragon, and this is where the story has an unexpected and catastrophic end. She destroys what she had protected and nurtured for so long. The movie's ending is reminiscent of how 'Kung Fu Panda' ended – the flower that you see in the end is both a symbol of peace and the regret in Sintel's mind.

The movie is not a happy, feel-good entertainer; rather, it is shocking and gloomy. But what sets it apart is the

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